# EXECUTIVE SEARCH FIRM – SUPERINTENDENT, VANCOUVER PUBLIC SCHOOLS

## REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL # 2025-009

## General Specifications

## 1. Introduction

The Vancouver School District #37 (District) is an urban district located within both the City of Vancouver and Clark County, Washington (across the Columbia River from Portland, Oregon) extending over fifty-eight square miles with a student population of 23,000 and a full and part-time employee base of approximately 3,500 employees. The District is made up of thirty-eight (38) schools and several support buildings/locations. Vancouver Public Schools has been nationally recognized for community schools, digital transformation, and programs of choice. The District is an active member in the Digital Promise League of Innovative Schools and the National Coalition for Community Schools.

Dr. Jeff Snell, current superintendent of schools, has provided the Board of Directors ("Board") advanced notice of his intention to leave the district on June 30, 2025. The Vancouver Public Schools Board seeks written, informal proposals from experienced executive search firms or individuals to provide consulting services for a national search for a superintendent.

## 2. Timeline

The following schedule will be used for the implementation of this RFP.

| Date | Activity |
|---|---|
| May 16, 2025 | Board reviews RFP for the search process |
| Approx. May 22, 2025 | RFP distributed |
| June 2, 2025 | Deadline for submission of questions about the RFP at 10:00 a.m. |
| June 9, 2025 | Responses to RFP due at 1:00 p.m. local time |
| June 10-12, 2025 | Initial screening of proposals and selection of firms to be interviewed |
| June 16-20, 2025 | Interviews with finalist firms conducted (Committee of the Whole??) |

## 3. Scope of Work

An executive search firm or individual consultant with experience in the recruitment of superintendents for mid-sized school districts will assist the Board in conducting a comprehensive, inclusive, and effective search for the most qualified candidate.

### 3.1. Contractor Deliverables

The Board will work with the selected firm or individual to develop a superintendent search process and a timeline for the search activities. At a minimum, the activities will include:

1. Develop, for board adoption, a profile of desired characteristics for superintendent that incorporates the District's goals and the leadership characteristics that the Board and community consider requisite for success.
2. Demonstrate a candidate identification process that identifies a diverse pool of highly qualified and competent candidates in districts with a similar achievement and community context, reflecting a familiarity with our students' needs.
3. Advise the Board on a compensation package that facilitates successful recruitment of

the quality and experience of Superintendent desired.

4. Solicit applications nationally.
5. Develop, for board approval, hiring procedures to be used for the position.
6. Advise the Board regarding identification and assessment of candidates.
    a. Develop and distribute recruitment materials that will encourage qualified candidates to apply
    b. Conduct a national search that will include advertising the position broadly in print media as well as through an effective web-based strategy
    c. Conduct personal outreach recruiting to ensure that the applicant pool includes highly qualified candidates with diverse backgrounds and experiences
    d. Collect all relevant background information on potential candidates so that the strengths and weaknesses of each applicant can be assessed
    e. Assist the Board with pre screening candidates based on clearly delineated criteria
    f. Assist the Board (or possible advisory committee on the board's behalf) in evaluating the applicants against the qualifications and criteria developed to create a group of candidates for interviews
7. Assist with logistics of finalist interviews.
    a. Facilitate visits by the Board to the communities of the finalists
    b. Facilitate community forums and interviews with the finalists
8. Ensure a satisfactory conclusion to the search.
    a. Assist the Board in contract negotiations with the selected candidates

Understanding that discretion is of utmost importance to our district, as well as to many candidates, the search firm must maintain the confidentiality of all information collected as appropriate.

### 3.2. Contractor and Subcontractor Fingerprint-Based Criminal History Verification

The Contractors and individuals employed or contracted by Contractor, who will have direct, unsupervised contact with students, shall also be required to submit fingerprints and to undergo a state and nationwide fingerprinting and criminal history records check, in accordance with the provisions of RCW 43.43.830. The Education Service Department 112 provides fingerprinting services for Contractors. Individuals or the Contractor, and not the District, shall be responsible for the fees associated with fingerprinting and the criminal history records check, not to exceed the actual costs.

### 3.3. RFP Questions, Clarifications and Changes

Changes, additions, deletions or clarifications to this RFP will be supplied by email and posted as an addendum to the RFP. Any Proposer requiring clarification of the information provided in this solicitation must submit specific questions or comments in writing to Brett Blechschmidt, Chief Operating Officer. (brett.blechschmidt@vansd.org) Email is the preferred form of written communication. The deadline for submitting such questions is June 2, 2025 by 10:00 a.m. local time.

If selected for award, a proposer will be expected to execute a contract with the material terms and conditions of the sample contract included with the solicitation documents. The material terms and conditions of the sample contract may be modified at the sole discretion of the District upon determination that the modification is in the best interest of the District.

If the proposer selected for award as a result of this RFP fails to agree to a contract with the material terms and conditions of the sample contract attached, the District may terminate negotiations with the proposer and commence negotiations with the next highest ranked proposer.

## 4. Proposal Format, Content, and Submission

### 4.1. Proposal Format

District proposal standards:

a) Proposal includes Proposer Certifications and Representations Form, signed.
b) Proposal addresses all evaluation criteria in 4.3.
c) Proposal is complete and succinct; it does not include extraneous information.

### 4.2. Proposal Content

Address all Evaluation Criteria listed in Section below and in the order provided; include reference and cost attachments if requested. Include a completed Proposer Certifications and Representations:

### 4.3. Proposal Sections and Evaluation Criteria

| Criteria | Points |
|---|---|
| 1. Executive Summary. Provide a short summary that demonstrates your understanding of the scope of services required by the District and why your firm is best able to provide that scope of service, including the expertise and types of searches performed by your firm. | 10 |

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|---|---|
| 2. Experience.<br>a) Describe the capacity of your firm to perform the scope of work provided in Section 2. Describe how many superintendent searches for comparable districts your firm has completed in the last six years.<br>b) List the key staff proposed to perform the Work, if contracted. Describe the role of each key staff proposed and the percentage of their time allotted to the project. Note any staff or consultants connected to the region who would be serving a role in the search.<br>c) For each member of the project team, please provide a description of their experience and education, time with the company, and how their experience suits their role on the team. Include experience of staff with recruitment for a position in Washington.<br>d) Specify the number of superintendent searches in which each member has participated and in what capacity. Note the longevity of superintendents hired by members of this team or firm over the past six years. Describe any particularly noteworthy accomplishments of the superintendents placed. | 25 |
| 3. Work Plan. Provide details on the following:<br>a) The search activities and approach. Describe how your firm would recruit for the Washington region. Describe your understanding of what is unique or particular about education in Washington.<br>b) Methods you will use to communicate and work with the Board.<br>c) Methods you will use to recruit a diverse pool, to identify prospective candidates and promote their interest to apply. Include how you would ensure that the recruitment process is equitable and accessible, particularly to candidates from communities that have been historically marginalized. Describe how you address implicit bias in building and screening the applicant pool.<br>d) Describe how you will effectively engage stakeholders (staff, students, families, and the broader community) both in terms of collecting information to develop the initial position qualifications and evaluation | 40 |

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|---|---|
| criteria and in providing a meaningful way to generate, receive, and use their input in the evaluation of final candidates. Describe the firm's philosophy about what role these stakeholders play in selecting a superintendent. Describe how your firm has adapted its practices, policies, and environment in light of changing notions of institutional bias and systemic oppression.<br>e) Describe what the major challenges to a successful superintendent search are and how the project team will address them.<br>f) Estimate a reasonable timeline that the project team will use to guide the search process.<br>g) Describe the Information, services and assistance you will require from the Board and district staff to enable you to conduct the search. | |
| 4. Budget. Provide a budget with total not to exceed cost of services and payment terms. The budget should provide a breakdown of costs in the following areas:<br>a) Estimated cost by each scope of work section<br>b) Estimated hours spent by each member of the project team and their fees<br>c) Estimated travel expenses<br>d) Estimated advertising and postage expenses required to distribute information regarding the vacancy<br>e) Any other expenses | 25 |
| **Total Points** | **100** |

### 4.4. References

On the Proposer Reference Sheet, list a minimum of three school districts (of similar size and academic quality to the District, if possible) that have used your services for a superintendent search within the past six years. References should be prepared to address firm's ability to meet deadlines, accuracy of estimates, and quality of work.

### 4.5. Litigation Record

Include a statement of litigation record, indicating if within the last five years firm has been involved in litigation with any clients. If so, please give the name, date, and jurisdiction of each such matter, and a brief description of the nature of the dispute and the outcome.

### 4.6. Proposal Submission

All proposals must be received at the District Office as addressed below in sealed envelopes marked on the upper left hand corner with the name and address of the bidder and addressed to:

**Vancouver School District No. 37**
**Attn: Chief Operating Officer**
**2901 Falk Road**
**Vancouver, Washington 98661**

**They may be mailed via any delivery service or hand delivered. It is the responsibility of the submitting agency to ensure it is received by the due date and time.**

**Due by 1:00 p.m. on Friday, June 9, 2025.**

Submissions shall be prepared as standard 8-1/2 X 11 letter size and shall not exceed 20 pages, exclusive of required attachments. Adherence to the maximum page criterion is critical and each page side with criteria information will be counted toward the maximum number of pages. Front and back covers, table of contents pages, and tabbed divider pages will not be counted if they do not contain submission information.

Late proposals will not be accepted under any circumstance, and any proposal so received shall be returned to the proposing firm or filed without review by the District. Any questions or requests for clarification regarding this RFP should be directed in writing to the District's Chief Operating Officer, Brett Blechschmidt, per the timeline shown above.

## 5. Proposal Evaluation and Award

### 5.1. Proposal Evaluation

An evaluator, or evaluation committee, will evaluate the proposals. Each evaluator will independently evaluate and score proposals in accordance with the Evaluation Criteria. The first evaluation will result in two or more firms selected to interview, based on the highest evaluation score from Section 4.3 Evaluation and Score. The Board will hold interviews virtually the week of June 16, 2025. The Board will determine selection of the successful firm based on the overall evaluation of the proposal and interview.

### 5.2. Negotiation

### 5.3.

The District will commence serial negotiations with the highest-ranked eligible Proposer. At any time during negotiations, the District may terminate negotiations with the highest ranked Proposer, or the eligible Proposer with whom it is currently negotiating if the District believes that:

a) The eligible Proposer is not negotiating in good faith; or

b) Further negotiations or negotiations with the eligible Proposer will not result in the parties agreeing to the terms and conditions of the final Contract in a timely manner.

If the District terminates negotiations with an eligible Proposer, the District may then commence negotiations with the next highest-ranked eligible Proposer.

The District reserves the right to negotiate final contract terms with the selected Proposer(s) to the fullest extent allowed by law and as in the best interest of the District.

### 5.4. References

The District reserves the right to investigate references, including customers other than those listed in a Proposer's submission. This inquiry may include without limitation investigation of past performance of any Proposer with respect to its successful performance of similar projects, compliance with specifications and contractual obligations, completion or delivery of a project on schedule, and its lawful payment of employees and subcontractors.

## 6. RFP Terms and Conditions; Protest of Solicitation or Award

### 6.1. Proposer Cost of Response Preparation

Proposers will bear sole responsibility for all costs incurred in preparing and providing their proposals in response to this RFP.

### 6.2. Submitted Materials are District Property

All materials submitted for any proportion of a Proposal in response to this RFP, or during any tier of this solicitation, will become the property of the District and will not be returned to proposers.

### 6.3. Proposal Validity

Proposals will remain valid for a period of 60 days following the Proposal submission deadline.

### 6.4. Solicitation Cancellation, Rejection of a Proposal or All Proposals

The District may cancel the Procurement or reject any or all Proposals. The District is not liable to any Proposer for any loss or expense caused by or resulting from the cancellation of a solicitation or rejection of a Proposal.

### 6.5. Disputes

In case of any doubt or difference of opinion as to the items or service to be furnished under this RFP, or the interpretation of the provisions of the RFP, the decision of the District will be final and binding upon all parties.

### 6.6. Publicity

News releases relating to this RFP will not be made without prior approval by, and in coordination with the District.

### 6.7. Confidentiality

6.7.1. The district is subject to Public Disclosure laws, and dealings with the district and confidentiality covenants must qualify under this law. A proposal submitted in response to this RFP may contain proprietary and/or confidential data which the proposer does not want used or disclosed for any purpose other than evaluation of the proposal. The use and disclosure of any such data, subject to the provisions of the Freedom of

Information Act, may be so restricted, provided that the proposer marks the cover sheet of the proposal with the following legend, specifying the pages of the proposal which are to be restricted in accordance with the Conditions of the legend. Legend shall state "Confidential data contained in this proposal shall not be used or disclosed, except for evaluation purposes." If a contract is awarded to the proposer as a result of or in connection with the submission of this proposal, the district shall have the right to use or disclose this confidential data to the extent provided in the contract. This restriction does not limit the right of the district to use or disclose confidential data obtained from another source without restriction. The district assumes no liability for disclosure or use of unmarked RFP proposal data and may use or disclose the data for any purpose and may consider that the proposal was not submitted in confidence and therefore is subject to release.

6.7.2. The District will not disclose records submitted by a proposer that are exempt from disclosure under the Washington Public Records Law, subject to the following procedures and limitations:

a) The Proposer shall mark all proposal pages containing the records it has determined as confidential under Washington Public Records Law and shall segregate those pages in the following manner:

i. Such pages will be clearly marked "Confidential" on each page of the confidential document.

ii. Proposer will separate confidential pages from its other Proposal pages by providing the confidential pages to the District in a separate document.

iii. In its proposal, Proposer will cite the specific statutory exemption in Washington Records Law exempting such pages from disclosure.

iv. Items above will prevail in the event these provisions conflict with formatting or response instructions elsewhere in this document.

v. Proposers may not mark an entire Proposal confidential. Should a proposal be submitted in this manner, the District will hold no portion of the proposal as confidential, unless such a portion is segregated as per this section and is determined exempt from Washington Public Records Law.

6.7.3. Notwithstanding the above procedures, the District reserves the right to disclose information that the District determines, in its sole discretion, is not exempt from disclosure or that the District is directed to disclose by the Clark County District Attorney or a court of competent jurisdiction.

6.7.4. Prior to disclosing such information, the District will make reasonable attempts to notify the proposer of the pending disclosure.

## 7. Contract Terms and Conditions

### 7.1. Contract Award and Term

The District intends to award a single contract as a result of this RFP. The contract term will be one year, with up to four additional one-year renewals as agreed by both Parties.

### 7.2. Sample Contract

Proposers are advised to thoroughly review and familiarize themselves with the District sample standard contract. The successful proposer will be invited to enter into a contract in substantially the form attached hereto. Any contract resulting from this RFP shall be based on the RFP documents and in compliance with Vancouver School District Public Contracting Rules and the Public Contracting Code.

### 7.3. Insurance

Proposers are advised to carefully review the insurance requirements contained in the sample standard contract. Contractor will promptly provide Certificates of Insurance at the District's request.

### 7.4. File Review

After an Intent to Award has been issued, all proposers are welcome to view the solicitation and evaluation file at District offices. However, a debrief and/or copies of documents in the solicitation file will not be available until after a contract has been fully executed.